Bittersweet Memories

LAKSHMIPRIYA DEVI ON SHOOTING HER DEBUT FEATURE *BOONG* IN A BORDER TOWN AND THE IDEA OF 'OTHERNESS'

Manipuri filmmaker Lakshmipriya Devi was shooting her recently released debut feature *Boong* in Moreh, a small town on the India-Myanmar border, in late February of 2023. About a week later, the ethnic conflict between the Meiteis and Kukis broke out in the state. "There was a feeling that something was brewing. A bandh had been called, but we couldn't just sit in our hotel rooms. We shot outside the police station there, using their barricades to create a set and borrowing fruits and vegetables to 'dress' the empty stalls and carts. Just as we were about to start shooting, a Tamilian wedding procession went past, which helped because the streets were otherwise completely empty," she remembers. This border town has a diverse population, including significant Tamil, Gorkha and Marwari communities. And yet, the town, along with the rest of Tengnoupal district, has seen recurring ethnic violence in the two years since.

The film follows a schoolboy, Boong (Gugun Kipgen), who travels to Moreh to look for his missing father, who is presumed dead. Along with Boong is his best friend, Raju (Angom Sanamatum), who is considered an 'outsider' because he's from Rajasthan. This tender and charming coming-of-age film that also addresses xenophobia and bigotry premiered at the Toronto International Film Festival last year.



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The first time Lakshmipriya herself felt 'othered' was when she came to study in Delhi as a 10-year-old. "We had an *ayah* in the hostel and she used to whack us on our thighs with a rod, saying you people from the Northeast eat too much," she recalls. This was followed by years of racist slurs as she went on to study Mass Communication at Jamia Millia Islamia. Every time she returned home in Imphal, she'd notice how the same was happening to people from outside over here. "Wherever there is a majority, they will always try and subjugate the minority."

Lakshmipriya, who has worked as an assistant director on films such as *Luck by Chance*, *Rang De Basanti* and *PK*, describes *Boong* as "my bittersweet memory of Manipur". She wrote this film about eight years ago after the passing of her father, and it was inspired by the legends she had heard about her great-grandfather. "He was said to be in exile in Myanmar, and everyone had different theories about him. I always wondered if he'd recognise me or even my mother, his granddaughter." The 52-year-old, who wants to tell more stories from her state, is happy that her fellow Manipuris are watching the film. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay